

Dead in the Water — GM Story Bible

The single source of truth. Players never see this document. Everything else (character sheets, clue deck, GM guide, Last Night doc) is built on top of it.

The Setting

A family lake house in Gig Harbor, Washington. A long weekend in summer. Friday arrival, Saturday party, Sunday morning a body in the shallows. Dry house — no alcohol, just an aggressively stocked mocktail bar, an ice cream chest freezer, and Richard's personal case of glass-bottle root beer.

The Victim: Richard “Dick” Crookshank

Age 62. Self-made hotel magnate. Founder of **Crookshank Inns**, a chain of 23 mid-tier motels along the I-5 corridor from Bellingham to San Diego. Lives alone on Bainbridge Island in a house full of nautical antiques and one foul-mouthed parrot named **Solomon**.

Family connection. Richard is the **10th step half-brother** of Hank Whitfield (the family patriarch) — a genealogical link so distant it took an Ancestry.com algorithm and three glasses of root beer to surface it. He has clung to it anyway. For the past year he has been writing letters, sending oddly specific gifts (an engraved lobster fork, a single nautical chart of Gig Harbor with one cove circled in red), and dropping hints that he plans to “make his only living family the heirs of the Crookshank Inns estate.” This running gag is the project's signature: the family barely understands how he's related to them.

Personality. Theatrical, charming on demand, casually cruel, loves a grand reveal. Carries a worn leather portfolio everywhere. Travels with his own case of glass-bottle root beer and refuses to drink anything else. Always seems to be testing people. The kind of man who'd say “I'll be honest with you” and then absolutely not be.

Family nicknames. Close family call him “Dick.” Everyone else, “Richard.” The GM gets to deliver “Dick is dead” Sunday morning with a perfectly straight face.

Solomon the parrot. Richard brings Solomon everywhere. Solomon repeats things he overheard the night before. He is canonically an unreliable witness. He is also a recurring comedy beat the GM can lean on whenever the room gets too quiet. Signature line, screeched at maximum volume whenever the energy dips: **“WHERE'S MY ROOT BEER!”**

The Cast (locked)

Real name	Fictional persona	Role
Daniel	Hank Whitfield	Patriarch / Obvious Suspect
Nicole	Catherine Whitfield	Matriarch / Sinner
Sophia	Vivienne “Vivi” Hawthorne	Accomplice
Jaymon	Sebastian Hawthorne	Killer
Alex	Alexander (the house manager)	GM-in-fiction / not a suspect
Samantha	Isabelle “Bella” Reyes	Sinner
Colin	Beau Whitfield	Sinner
Emma	Eden Hartley	Sinner
Luke	Levi Whitfield	Sinner
Ben	Cody Whitfield	Sinner with the hero turn

Family naming notes. The Whitfields are the family. The Hawthornes (Vivi and Sebastian) live in NYC; their wedding was in the *Times* style section three years ago. Eden Hartley is Beau’s longtime girlfriend, treated as family. Bella Reyes is Alexander’s off-script real-life fiancée; in the fiction she’s just a guest. Alexander is not a Whitfield — he’s the lake house’s hired resident manager, beloved but neutral.

The Setup

For the past year, Richard has been *auditioning* the family — surprise visits, pointed phone calls, small loyalty tests. He announced he would reveal his final will at **midnight Saturday, on the lake house dock**, in front of everyone. He arrived Friday with the leather portfolio, his case of root beer, and a freshly notarized envelope.

Saturday was the buildup: lake activities, an obscene amount of grilled food, a sunset boat ride, lawn games, a giant mocktail bar, a bonfire, fireworks at 11 PM. Midnight on the dock was supposed to be the reveal.

It never happened.

The Crime

Sunday morning, Richard is found face-down in the shallows beside the dock. The notarized envelope is missing from his portfolio. One of the brass dock cleats — already wobbly all weekend, a detail several family members had complained about — has been pulled loose and is gone. (It is at the bottom of the lake. The GM’s clue deck recovers it in Phase 2.)

Time of death: roughly **11:40 PM**. Richard had walked out to the dock alone around 11:30 PM to “rehearse his speech.”

Cause of death: blunt force from the loose brass cleat, followed by a fall and a head strike against a piling on the way into the shallow water.

The True Story (GM eyes only)

Saturday afternoon, Richard pulled **Vivienne** aside privately. He saw her as his Princess, his publicly favored heir, and he wanted her to be the first to know that the entire Crookshank Inns fortune was going to **TURD — Tortoise Urgent Rescue Division**, a charity he had quietly become obsessed with after rescuing a tortoise from a Bremerton parking lot two years ago. He told Vivi he hoped she'd be proud of him. She smiled, said she was, and walked back to the boathouse to find Sebastian.

What Richard didn't know: both Hawthornes had been quietly drowning. Sebastian had MBA debt and an NYC apartment lease he could only afford if the inheritance came through. Vivi had been secretly writing Richard for months begging for help to leave PR for the theater she'd always loved. *Neither had told the other how desperate they had become.* Saturday afternoon, when Vivi told Sebastian about TURD, they both saw the same cliff at the same moment.

They planned it together in the boathouse over the next two hours. Sebastian would do it. Vivi would handle distraction. They argued briefly about the cleat (Vivi had noticed it loose all weekend), then agreed. Take the cleat, take the envelope, push him into the shallows, throw the cleat into the lake. Without a found will, the estate would tangle in probate and might still come back to the family.

At **11:30 PM** Vivi gathered everyone at the bonfire for "one last s'more" and launched into a long, performative story about a Broadway opening she'd been to. (It was the same story she had told at last Christmas dinner — that detail surfaces in Phase 5.) She kept the family riveted while Sebastian "stepped outside for some air."

At **11:25 PM**, just before her story, Vivi slipped up to the primary suite balcony with a pair of opera binoculars and confirmed the dock was empty and no one else was approaching. She came back downstairs and started the Broadway story at **11:30 PM** on schedule. (The opera binoculars stay on the balcony loveseat — she doesn't get a chance to retrieve them before the body is found Sunday morning.)

At **11:35 PM** Sebastian walked to the dock, argued with Richard, grabbed the loose cleat, swung once, watched Richard fall and strike the piling on the way down, threw the cleat into the lake, and took the notarized envelope from the leather portfolio. He returned to the bonfire at **11:50 PM** and slipped the envelope into the inside pocket of his blazer. The blazer is on the back of his chair at breakfast Sunday morning.

At **11:55 PM** Vivi briefly excused herself upstairs, balled up a sticky note that said "*breathe. it's done.*", dropped it in the master bathroom trash, and came back down at 12:02 AM.

Sunday morning, both Hawthornes act shocked. Their alibis cross-cover each other. They lie *for* each other.

Structure: Killer + Accomplice + Eight Sinners

Every player has a guilty secret from that night. Two are guilty of the murder. The rest are red herrings — guilty of something, but not this.

The Killer (Sebastian Hawthorne). Pulled the trigger. Has the missing notarized envelope on his person Sunday morning. Cool, sarcastic, lying about a fifteen-minute “smoke break” that was actually twenty.

The Accomplice (Vivienne Hawthorne). Knew about TURD before anyone else. Planned with her husband. Provided the alibi distraction at the bonfire. Lying for him and for herself.

The Eight Sinners. Each carries a guilty unrelated secret that surfaces during the game and looks suspicious until cleared:

- **Hank Whitfield** — shoved Richard in the boathouse around 8 PM (Solomon witnessed and now repeats fragments).
- **Catherine Whitfield** — slipped into Richard’s room around 9:30 PM and stole back the draft of her thinly-veiled family memoir, then burned it in the bonfire.
- **Bella Reyes** — confronted Richard alone at 7 PM about a humanitarian-non-profit donation he’d been stringing her along on; he laughed at her.
- **Beau Whitfield** — stole Richard’s case of root beer at 10 PM in retaliation for being mocked over a “Beau Thats Hot” merch pitch.
- **Eden Hartley** — went to Richard’s room around 9 PM, ostensibly to thank him for a leather-bound book of his late mother’s poems he’d given her privately Friday. Once inside, she opened the leather portfolio out of suspicion (Richard had told her Friday he was including her grandparents in the will, and she’d grown to suspect he was lying) — she saw the paper marked “\$60M → TURD (*final*)” in his handwriting. She took the book of poems, left a thank-you note as cover, rearranged a photo frame on the desk, and walked out. **She has known the truth about TURD since 9 PM Saturday and told no one.** In Phase 4 she steps forward after Cody’s photo reveal and corroborates — two witnesses to the same paper, which locks in the motive.
- **Levi Whitfield** — snuck out 10 PM to 12:30 AM to play poker (with chips, no money — he’ll keep clarifying this) on his rich friends’ three-tier houseboat. Got Alexander to cover for him.
- **Cody Whitfield (the youngest)** — snuck into Richard’s guest room Saturday afternoon out of pure curiosity, opened the leather portfolio, saw a paper that said “\$60M → TURD (**final**)” and took a photo on his phone. Didn’t tell anyone. **The photo is the clue that cracks the case in Phase 4.**

Alexander is not a Sinner. He is the neutral observer who runs the timeline.

The Knives Out Shape (two-stage reveal)

The case unmask in two waves.

Wave one — Phase 4: Sebastian. Cody's phone photo establishes the TURD motive. The smoke-break timeline doesn't add up. The notarized envelope is found in Sebastian's blazer. Sebastian breaks. The room thinks the case is solved.

Wave two — Phase 5: Vivienne. A small detail surfaces: Vivi's Broadway story at the bonfire was the same story she told at Christmas dinner. She was filling time on purpose. Hank or Catherine is the one who notices. The Princess was the architect. The reveal *aches* because it recontextualizes everything Vivi said and did all weekend.

Four threads the family must connect across the evening:

1. The loose dock cleat (recovered from the lake in Phase 2)
 2. The missing notarized envelope (found in Sebastian's blazer in Phase 4)
 3. The "stepped outside for air" alibi that lasted twenty minutes
 4. The Saturday afternoon conversation between Richard and Vivi (only Cody's photo plus Vivi's repeated Christmas story confirms she was the one Richard told)
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Tonal Anchors (do not lose these)

- Richard's voice and theatrics carry the comedy even when he is the corpse.
- The 10th-step-half-brother joke is the project's running gag and should appear at least three times.
- Solomon the parrot is at the lake house, repeats fragments of overheard conversations (especially the boathouse fight), and screeches "WHERE'S MY ROOT BEER" at peak volume whenever the room gets too quiet.
- The killers' motive is *earned* — not cartoon greed but two real, painful "my whole life depended on this" stories that the family discovers were running in parallel without the spouses ever telling each other.
- TURD must be said aloud, with full earnestness, by the GM, multiple times.
- Hank's "no politics in this house" rule is a recurring beat — even non-political clue cards get the treatment if a player tries to make them about something.
- Cody (the 14-year-old) gets the hero clue. His photo is the case-cracker. Build him up to it.